

god
bug

Iam H. Appy

Godbug

PREFACE

This essay could be described as little piece of anti-epicurean excess. Much suggested by those two thousand year old words is, you'll find, rejected. In its place: an embarrassed romanticism; a stoic frankenstein; a reluctant christism. 1

Everything epicurean is true. There are sufficient goods out there which fill you up if you have the good sense to find them. Control of desire; no bowing to frivolous dreams. The gods not being concerned about us means dreaming is futile. 2

- 3 It's funny how far something like christianity stretches beyond its initial image as an intellectually offensive metaphysics. Not only does the christian think God is *only* concerned about us, he is also an addict of λόγος, that wispy machine of hallucinated desire, something the epicurean despises. Contrary to the christian, you don't need λόγος to live well; you don't need it to live at all. For the epicurean atheist it's the closest thing to the devil. It is indeed a ghost, and, yes, it unfolds in your mind just like Jesus said it would.
- 4 I'll even say this: on matters of λόγος, christianity doesn't take things far enough. It smells saving sweetness in the decadent mental indulgence of words—and it proclaim words singular, the Word, the Word of God. Not a world of ghosts but a holy ghost. To the christian – and every other similar monogod religion orbiting near – everything else, every other twisted, beautiful child of λόγος, is a whispering piper who lives inside your ear. And so they get to drawing up prohibitions.

I see these religions as warning signs. And perhaps many atheists would say hey me too—but I really do find a lot of good in them as well (well, christianity). The recognition of λόγος – represented through words but of course λόγος goes beyond words – and the decadent, rebellious lack of care: I have to say I really like it. I’m a romantic and I can’t shake it. I like bad things. But like I said these religions ruin it all by letting themselves get eaten by words; and their inner extremism comes bursting out as they think to put up any defence is a kind of weakness, that moderation – epicurean now – is a failure of devotedness. It’s the whole world or nothing. It’s why religion only has believers and no one ever says “I got this neat idea from islam”.

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But still I get a lot out of christianity, I’ll admit it. I’m a bit wary making all these concessions, not just because non-christians would find it weird but because it runs the risk of the demented devotees to the two millenia old torture cult taking it as an endorsement of every awful thought they’ve whipped themselves into loving.

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I get a lot out of christianity because I am a fellow lover of λόγος. Everything clicked for me when I found out the epicureans hated poetry and mathematics. Like of course they did! Mathematics is completely *vicious*. Perhaps that sounds strange. But there are some who find their virtue lies in vice; vice is a part of their lives; they don't run from it. Vice is a part of their lives—and so too is malaise. Mathematicians, poets, the religious: all are creatures of malaise. And, for the poet, shame too. Shame is the poet's disease; its symptom is inertia. The mathematician is protected from shame by the raw shining power of the virtue he's able to find, and does find. The religious, eaten by wispy nothing words, giddy on the possibility of mental self-cannibalisation, is completely shameless. But the poet maintains his shame; he can't wish it away; he's eternally embarrassed. Constantly in the middle of things, he's unable to find the fat of thought yet he doesn't blind himself because of it. What reason is there to read a big complicated book? I don't think there is any. There's probably every reason not to. It's certainly not a virtuous thing; it doesn't make you

‘better’. Yet the poet spends his life writing such dark and damp things, reading them too. From the epicurean perspective – which, again, is so right – the big book is nothing but a snare; a way of passing on vice. Entrapment, bad faith, compulsion, evil.

They make vice sound like the worst thing ever. It does hurt. But, as I just said, the vice-seeker, though unwillingly perhaps, shoulders his vice because he sees his good lying somewhere else. The epicurean love of ease and the suspicion of desire is so sensible, as is the identification of objective goods and the possibility of living a life-well-lived. But it is true that in the rejection of λόγος the epicurean relinquishes his right to a finer perception. His good feelings and emotional satiety dull him to distinctions in the world, real distinctions. At its worst his epicureanism is a total awful stupidity: his disdain for mathematics is his disdain for everything similarly superfluous; his inability to see mathematics is his inability to see the world. Christianity imagines a community of sinners; a boring, fanatical, uncreative community. A world

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of epicureans is one of perceptual poverty and existential limitation, though they laugh.

- 9 To speak of poets—I consider the poet as a wider category than just a writer of pretty words. Sounds pretentious but he’s a maker of λόγος. He is a maker of λόγος and he’s also adept at letting in λόγος, if he’s earned his poetic cap. And he’s also good at letting λόγος go; maybe he’s half-epicurean after all. Still, he’s stranded between the dumb destruction of the epicurean and the dire self-immolation of the religious. The mathematician has found heaven, as far as I’m concerned.

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THE FUTURE

I took a ferry to France and on the way I met two Americans. Kind people who spoke to everyone: it looked like they were speaking to the ship's captain at one point. I got to speak to them too on the bus to Calais-Ville. They asked what I was doing. One presciently mentioned writing. I said yes—but I didn't tell them everything. I told them I was writing about something else. I didn't feel like I could tell them everything. How could

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I? Understanding stops here. Something like this is no nice thing. It's no nice sight.

- 2 How much can disappear and not matter? I mean all those things that lack immediate reality: they die, and in dying show us that they were always unnecessary. Things that were once everything to everyone can fade into nothing as if their whole existence was half-hearted. But all those other things which hit you with undeniable force, things like money, live on, laughing. They're full-blooded; we can touch them. Things like them make sense, are sense. I mean, there's so much else which is obscure and black—yet these things lie there well-lit, crystal clear intelligences. Oh they have immediate reality. And it really does seem like they're getting brighter and brighter.

- 3 I came back to Kant after a time away. Reading him again, I couldn't help but laugh a bit. The hubris: "My chief aim in this work has been thoroughness; and I make bold to say that there is not a single metaphysical problem that does not find its solution, or at least the key to its solution, here." Though I admit he admits his hubris a few sentences on. But what does it mean that

Kant tried to make his big book make as much sense as possible? He lay under a sense rock and let it smother him. Eager sense-stitching. But, learning to speak, language doesn't make sense and then it does. Everything doesn't make sense and then it does; and even when it does it doesn't really. So not making sense is—what? Nothing? Natural? Not so bad when ya think about it? Well it's not a style, nonsense. Style's something seeable. But think of a book written badly, written without due care to sense. A book unreadable. But unreadable is what? A lack of sense. Yet language is a lack of sense that's made into sense. It didn't start out making sense. Besides, doesn't sense block the making? Block the unfolding? If I understood language before I understood it there'd be nothing to understand. So what does this mean for these immediately intelligible things? No work needed to build a bridge—so no bridge built.

- 4 Why do mathematicians look so weird? It's like they can't help but become it. The mathematician lives up there in high abstraction, fighting an obscurity so obscure it doesn't know what it is. There's no obscurity like the obscurity of mathematics. A given perfect infinite nonsense. Free from easy understanding, easy intelligibility. Domain of pure obscurity: it leaves its mark if you don't resist. Easy answers killed by abstraction. Obscurity dissolved by a colony of intuition, leaving a mark telling where and what.
- 5 Mathematicians live in the dark. They are always prelanguage. I come to my language but with my language I always eventually stop (though I'm trying to walk again). Mathematics does not stop. And it's all so given. Out in the world everything stupidly crystal clear—darkness a precious precious resource. But in mathematics the mind behind the mind can't avoid it. Free from easy greedy thoughts that seek to make things their own. Instead thoughts are forced to adjust themselves in front of it.

One hundred years has told us a poem is not meant to be beautiful. But there's more: a poem is not meant to be good. If it's good – here meaning immediate – then it's failed (by succeeding). Leave the good work to the good worker, the poet is a bad bad writer. No spell-binding frontier-living. He's life pitiful. But who really cares about words? Old thinking; now they're just things I say now like 'it was good' or 'I'll have that one' or 'who cares about words'. Words out the usine with their usevaleur.

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There are things we can't help but feel. Again, things like money. My body likes money like my body likes music. Here, in a world made out of these things, nothing works except what is felt, and what is felt is truly universal, without gates and guards, or close to it. As for talk, all talk now defers to bodies. Words are weak; they smile all gummy. The great confrontation with nothing and no one is definitely not a body thing. Besides, it was all such an effort and now we simply don't have to. Because it really makes no difference and it doesn't matter at all.

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- 8 The poet is a bad writer. What does that really mean? That poetry is not a virtuous thing? Virtue knitted into quality and show. But the bad can also grow. A lot or maybe all of the good is just what we like and what we know. We value what we see and what we like. Which is maybe why, when eyes are turned to clear virtue, turned to clarity itself, there are only games: made things made unambiguous, resolvable, winnable; straight paths lined and paved and regularly cleaned. But soon our games will be nothing, will make nothing for anyone, and will stand next to what was no game and seem the same. Because the values of the future are different.
- 9 Time not the here and now of my time, synonymous motion time, equations at the speed of light. Time now rather the inevitable flick into the arbitrarium and the abattoir. Speak well, sing well, dance well, look well, they say. But in the twiney tensation of time the bad and good mix to unity. So why take so much care to make it all nice and round, memorable of something else nice and round? Chucking it in the recognition

machine, hoping it spits out something for everyone. The time mother will just pick it apart. Every little symmetry and happy assertion will eventually make a little less sense. And then there's a time where the pretty sphere made and carefully polished in the present will be full of holes. Even the little note written in diamond metal to explain it all, even that'll be all holey.

I'm still thinking about how Kant really tried to make his book make sense (the first one, the big one). You think you want to make for the future but time kills that too. No archaeology will save you. No genealogy either. Did Kant not see that when he wrote the *Prolegomena zu einer jeden künftigen Metaphysik, die als Wissenschaft wird auftreten können*? I mean, isn't everything he meant just contained in that title? *Prolegomena* to any future metaphysics that will be able to present itself as a science. Writing the prologue to the future. But how far into the future did he think it would last? Mathematics survives time because it's not made by us. But Kant thought he with his bare naked hands could find something that survives the inevitable death of sense, the

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heat-death of the human heart. What an act of defiance, properly as he said and thought of himself: an enlightened enlightenment man, fighting all forces adversarial. Stubborn spirit and hopeful. But sense is such a delicate, fragile and weak, pliable and pluckable thing, always on the run.

II Call it pragmatism with a small p: if time is going to strip all the careful weaving, leaving it all senseless (it will get through any toy wall) then sense is just senselessness delayed. Found in a bundle in a sufficient future the senseless and the senseful lie together like buried enemies made to hold hands like lovers. Kant tried to make it all make sense, all the way to the end of his life. Did he ever doubt it? What does it mean that sense for him was real and unarbitrary? Friendly correspondence between sense and truth; penpals behind the ears. The same. And all the effort: ten years, sweat, struggle, making better, explaining clarifying into elucidity. If makes sense then true. Weaker: if makes sense then might not be true but must make sense to be true. Maybe Kant thought himself a bit like a god. So then is time the devil? He thought that metaphysics was beat

up by time because nobody before him had given much thought as to how to beat it back. And then none of what he wrote made sense anyway! He pushed so far into sense he got all the way through into nonsense. And maybe so in that way despite himself he saved himself, gave some work to those who like work. But sense, his sense, the sense he thought he was scratching into stone, is of course controlled in a higher sense by time: we may try to make sense but sense is only made first by time. And only unmade. So what does it mean that Kant desired to make against time?

MATHEMATICS

But the danger in writing with time – writing in the form of time; that is, writing with the knowledge of one’s unmaking, one’s intelligible death – is that sometimes I want to say what would be said to be a sincere thing, a sincere thing like that the young and the dead always say, because I’m still a person who will die and so I feel it to say sense, to communicate. I’m not that far gone yet. Here’s a sentence: the feeling of affinity that mathematics produces in a person is not some ac-

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cidental nicety but something fundamental, and fundamental not just to mathematics but to aesthetics generally.

3 First go to art. Art: a word changed; a word ripped apart and put back again only to be ripped back again and then put apart. Art today is funny: what is it but hypnosis? And not just art but everything: objects hypnotise, silky flows across my fingers I never notice. It's like everything is shaped like my hand. Who is the artist? Give yourself up to the end, complete the circle, I need not be anything when I have my art: bind me, blind me, shock me, make me feel what you want me to feel. Art not just unnatural but anti-natural. The world's no gesamtkunstwerk.

4 Oh the artist could never be a mathematician. Start again. The artist and the mathematician rarely mix. Dürer? Escher? (Knew Pólya and Coxeter.) Lewis Carroll? Keep it at that. Or let's say it yet another way. The artist of *today* could never be a mathematician: at least, as long as he maintained his artist preservery and reservery, not willing to give it up, mathematics would be lost to him. Equally, the mathematician and art:

how's he got time for that? Mathematics calls and it never stops calling. It's a voice that gets in your head and takes over your life. But the voice is loved. And this is where it gets nice. Look at mathematics. What to see? Frustration, austerity, pain, pain in thought, sheer unbreakable difficulty. Lots of failure. Lots of time alone. Frequent sense of irrelevancy. Tearful abstraction. A life-work summed up in a sentence like: every preshaded functed foil is trivially unladen under homogenous tunnels into the zero packs of sacks of nontrivial dimension under the assumption of the general pushforward conjecture of Eckleton. There's nothing like it. But the mathematicians talk of beauty. And love. They really love it. (And when I say they I also mean we: I feel it a glorious privilege to feel too this rare wonderful connection to this absolutest of abstractions, this precious precious thing that is all my own, part of me.) And all these things really are there, they're not lying. Isn't it a kind of paradox?

5 Now compare the artist, the contemporary artist. Perhaps we can call him by what he is: the most uncomplicated thing; the simple-single-souled. (And, before you think I talk unjustly, though I wouldn't call it a privilege – though I'm not sure I think it's a misfortune either – I have from time to time tasted a bit of this art feeling. Maybe the privilege here is in having a taste for many different tastes.) What's paradox for him? He hides when it comes round. He likes his food where he can see it. He likes it prechewed preferably. He's a surface swimmer. And that's fine! But this is why the artist today if he stayed an artist couldn't be a mathematician: to even pretend to get how something which causes so much pain could be pursued with so much force, so much endlessly endless energy? (And then be loved!) His eyes would touch. Understanding unbreachable, uncrossable. No the artist must really see his beauty. Isn't that obvious?

The mathematician is an aesthetician and the artist is an anaesthetician. Mathematician as aesthetician can wait. But the artist as anaesthetist? Though again isn't it obvious? Just because he has a favourite shade of blue doesn't mean he's in the game of livening up your senses. Maybe when painting was painting flowers and bowls of fruit – when the grip of the art object was weak and clammy, too young – the effect was too puny for the viewer to be held and controlled. But we are far away from those paintings now (and why now painting is not painting but a fun form of money. And it's why art shows make you feel a bit slimy). Take it like this. What's the experience of watching a film? If you make films maybe you notice special secret things. But assume you don't make films. What's the experience? I'll tell you: a big invisible hand comes out the screen ties strings to your eyeballs and puts a saddle across your brain. Resist all you want my ami you do not matter: the drama is law. You will feel all the lunges and lifting ups, you will feel the corkscrew essence of its motion restructuring your soul wrapping your mind tongue in bits. You can love it or you can

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think it's terrible; you can even think it's boring. You can think whatever you want because the thing, the drama, is lordly indifferent to you. You'll feel it all the same. Or, now, take the most painful pop song you know. Even this is something: how can pop music be associated with so much pain? It's like mathematics but only because it's like its perfect opposite, its antithesis: the surface is so sugary sweet that you feel it as an injection into your very you yet go near it and you become ashamed of yourself like you've just sinned against something big; yes, you hate it because it's so sugary so slick and sick yet so appealing. There is deep hate, deep hate in your bones, you want to get as far away as possible. It's too easy. It's a trap. Who made this horror weapon? It's a brain bomb. It's deceptive in all the wrong ways. People who like pop music must all be secret killers just waiting for their chance. (And seen with eyes Pauline: unfathomable difference, unfathomable immorality.) Even though you hate it you love it (your body loves it). Give yourself up. Don't resist. The unbreakable and purest Dionysian cleavage and intersewing of the

real and unreal and all the turmoil of the emotions: Toxic on eternal loop.

Now, last, look to visual art. I mean everything that's come after paintings and sculptures, after when these were everything. Somewhere sometime about a century ago. Something I sometimes like to think about: how could van Gogh basically destroy the Earth with armageddon flames and then rebuild it all anew just by painting squiggly churches and people with yellow skin? Is it because he's like a book? Maybe I'm too far away. But I mean it. I'll admit *l'origine du monde* still packs a punch. But Manet with his naked people eating breakfast *sur l'herbe*? And where's the revolution in cubism? ("You need education, you need history. Read a book! It happened!") I know it happened. But how can feeling change so much?

Visual art today; it's all kinds of things. But look at what there is. Everything's big, everything's bright, everything's a thousand repetitions intersecting across the empty space of a warehouse hanger—or it's also nothing, it's the size of my palm, it's unpainted, it's just a painting of a table-

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cloth, it's just a tablecloth, it's just a table. But even these last nothings are somethings. Visual art, motionless visual art, is like a clumsy little brother of all what we may call the temporal arts. Because life is temporal, the world is temporal, and so in this way film and music luxuriate in their world-creations liberally mimicking the movements of our inner selves (hence the hypnosis: they are soul simulations). But visual art tries very hard to play along. Let's think with words for a second: visual art may not hypnotise but it does do it's best to *mesmerise*. And this does the same thing or close enough. It can't make you dream against your dreamest dreams—but it can hold you still for a second and stop you thinking of anything else, take you out of you. It's the artworld Kant and Schopenhauer spent all their pennies scheming about. Schopenhauer would be filling himself up on all the contemporary aesthetic devilry he could find: anything to just take him away. (Ethical imperative after all.) These things strike dumb in awe. Bring in the sublime don't be shy I'll show you God I made him this

morning (oh yes you thought right, I am just that good).

But I started out by talking about mathematics.

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What was my plain statement again? The feeling of affinity that mathematics produces in a person is not some accidental nicety but something fundamental, and fundamental not just to mathematics but to aesthetics generally. So what was all that talk about art? Let's go to mathematics. Yes mathematics is thought of as an aesthetic thing. If outsiders have their trope that maths is dead and dull well then the mathematicians searched through hell to find their own to make their revenge with: that maths is beautiful and the mathematician is guided by his eyes and his nose just as much as his brain. I mean, it's completely true. But on this aesthetical extravagance, it's not just a nice coincidence that maths appears so beautiful and the pull so strong yet not like the pull of a pop song. You go to mathematics because you really love it and you really feel you must. Ask a mathematician why mathematics is beautiful and maybe he'll say something about the perfection of its properties: how everything fits together in

a godly prior structure without holes and blemishes; the unique allowance of the mind to shoot off under and over infinities, infinities peppered with diverse stops of finitude; the humanly satisfaction of coming to a solid piece of fat fact after a long hunt in desert with no water. The sublimity of real enlightenment, no show no lies. So then maybe some would deduce the love from the so-so objective properties of mathematics, properties supposedly lying hidden in wait all sheepish and coy, there only if you care to look.

II But let's play Kant for a second. Many of these reasons seem a bit made up. What if the feeling came before it all? That – let's not shy – the properties of mathematics really are actually how they look: difficult, frustrating, dry, boring (yes boring!). But none of this matters because these all exist in a wonderfully obscure contradiction: that not even independent of these things but in a strange way because of them, the affinity grows. Grows in the dark like something ingested not meant to be. An unlife force taken into me meaning more than me. What if mathematics does something, like sets in motion an unfolding pro-

cess inside of me, something that makes me feel very very close to mathematics, makes me love it? What if the affinity came first? And, to end playing Kant: is it not this affinity that becomes the a priori that 'makes mathematics possible'? This deep characteristic of mathematics, this process of unfolding affinity. It's funny: you can't imagine someone a mathematician – a real mathematician – and for them not to feel this affinity. It's right in there along with the admiration of Galois' fire, an essential pebble unable to be unfelt.

Art hypnotises, mesmerises. I am not myself when I am with art today. But mathematics really does not hypnotise. And it's certainly nothing like visual art either it doesn't mesmerise. Yes sometimes there's a breakthrough; yes sometimes (often) everything explodes into the light. Yes sometimes (often) a proof grips me and I can't think of anything until it's done. But this is not the same. The mathematician must sometimes drag himself to his pen and desk; I'm sure he enjoys his breaks away from it, gives him a chance to learn something new. Yet he has this thing inside him this inner capacity, almost a new kind of

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emotion – like reverence, love, wonderment, the dribbliest hedonism, all unneatly folded into one – and this is what compels him. He begins with the affinity. An affinity that exists almost in itself, sealed off from outside properties, instead imbuing the outside properties with feeling and makes them appear as properties with loving qualities. What kind of mind pursues this so willingly? And of course artists love art (they would know most of all). Only the game is different; and it's one that looks like the world today. Why do these two modes exist? One where the object repels yet we love and pursue it because of something inside us, another where the object compels all charming and sweet yet we are able feel an inner repulsion (and yet can't escape it)?

GODBUG

- What does it mean that now we have an endless
pick of ways to keep the world out of the room?
The godbug that crawls out from under the table
after everyone else leaves—Spinoza's God: not
the table salt and the microwave but the thing
that remains when everything else is gone. 1
- The undeniable necessity of a thing is thought to
be its whole life and the beating heart of its signif-
icance. The force with which it insists on insert-
ing itself into your life. Because, if it dies, and you 2

don't miss it, then it couldn't have been much to begin with, could it? Not like our 'drives', hungers and addictions, innate and learned. Things which remind us of their existence even when we beg them not to, boney fingers tapping us on the forehead if we look away for too long.

- 3 Popular imagery has us painted as chattels to our deepest darkest desirant drives. That, hey, it mayn't seem it, but you're under control. Hammer blows to free will. That we don't decide our lives; our lives are run by forces that are both us and not us, idiots mocking egoists. But in tallying the drives and non-drives – thinking of a drive as something which recurs and which I need to feed – then the number of drives seems truly tiny.

- 4 Schopenhauer the Kant-lover transcendentalising the will. He said, though the will as it appears is unfree – controlled by outer world – the will in itself (the thing inside us, behind us, and beyond us) that will is free. This will does what it wills and we are under its rule—yet, as intelligible expressions of this dark will, some of this freedom can be applied to us too. No free personal will (who could be so silly to believe in that?) but

free superwill, the will that's there in the brick as well as in you. But, again, the number of drives is tiny. I don't eat, I feel hungry; I don't sleep, I feel tired. And sure I can be conditioned to live drive-like with all kinds of things: I eat sugar and then I don't, I feel off; I smoke and then I don't, I feel off; I look at the news and then I don't, oh yes I feel off. Yet there are things we can experience which do not instil a drive, spied by the fact they don't instil a hunger. Maybe the passionate will say what good is that? All's good comes out of monstrous hunger, eating the world with good intentions. But, yes, there are things which do not make me hunger for them, and so I have to return to them on my own, using my own two feet. Maybe I'm outing myself here but there's no hunger for mathematics, not in the same way anyway. There are no pangs of loss when away from it; often relief. Though I love it, it leaves me easily. Perhaps I wouldn't feel the pangs of loss if one day I could no longer speak either. These things that are embedded into me and they don't command me.

5 Of course my body needs certain things and can be made to need other things. How much of the addiction to nicotine is the control of the tobacco plant over us? We have receptors in our guts and brains that nicotine fits like a god given glove; the plant has evolved to control us—that's its will. And see how the whole party of sensations of inhaling and ingesting tobacco smoke – vile taste, harsh grating on throat – see how all that disappears after a little while, and breathing in these nicotine-laced clouds of burnt microparticulata becomes no different to breathing air—something tasteless, without feeling, something we are numb to. (For of course that's right in there as the essence of addiction—this vanishing act, this disappearance, our becoming numb.)¹ Yet the silence of these other things, these rich non-drives, makes me think: how much is out there that can be let in that I just don't know about, all because they're all so unassuming? These obscure things which we confront, which we let into ourselves, these things are different to these occupying drive-makers. The drives have

¹This was all an old thought that I'd long forgotten about.

the aesthetic glamour of being about control and freedomlessness, of being about things which kill us as well as things which keep us alive. It's literally life and death with these things. But these obscure things – these things which we must approach again and again (there are no drives here) – these things are not about bodily life and death, but about a kind of richness. And they allow us to share in some of their richness, feeding our lived life. They are gentle with us. (Which is what makes them so initially unappealing—we have to do all the work.) No sugar high, there's just good nutrition, good health. What are these things which are so generous and so gentle yet are things for which we have no need? These things die easily. Killed by their innecessity. Preoccupied by the glamour of drives, we miss these enormous invisible things. Still, they make a mockery of the idea that if a thing dies easily then it's weak, it's no good. These things are dying out of strength. The typical religious cosmoses which place us at

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and the plants control us. The tobacco plant uses me for its furtherance; the animal I eat I eat out of compulsion, controlled by some inner screaming blood-toothed devil. So see now Schopenhauer's bleak indifferent world, his rewrapping of the religious picture. The world does not care about you—nothing is for your will; no, everything is will. Yet for Schopenhauer this indifference led to an enslavement—a reversal of the religious free delight. The omni will did what it wanted and we did what it wanted. What we wanted was just a lonely dream in comparison. Faced with this prison-universe the lone person could only hope to stick his hand through the window bars, close his eyes and try to imagine he was some place else. Art and pity did that for Schopenhauer. Pity, the wilful quieting of the violent will – a quieting made the vessel of Nietzsche's phlegm – in relation to oneself as well as others (and in this way becomes a kind of self-pity), pity becomes for Schopenhauer the only weapon that we have against the will which will eventually end all. So, yes, it's true, there is freedom for Schopenhauer: the freedom to

breathe temporarily, the freedom to build vain little shacks of refuge.

But take the religious reversal further: why would the world care so much about us that it constantly pursues us and hunts us down? Maybe we're not even worthy as prey. The indifference of the world means it leaves us alone: we have to approach it. The drives and clamouring desires are there but small. And now with that an art no longer for arresting burning will but for getting will moving—opportunities to exercise sympathy. And what is will here now? It's not Schopenhauer's universal will but rather pointedly individual. But again no longer the reins and whips of inner drives but rather that delicate thing that's always running to nothing. It can barely get moving. This is will, this rare blossoming tied to certain obscure external things, isomorphic to the unfolding in relation to these things. Something that's not given but on the contrary must be worked at with infinite work to get it moving at all. But now forget art; every action can become like these gloriously giving things which enliven will. Or at least art can hope

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to. Will something quiet, something contingent,
something that does not force us to look at it.

POETS

Once the poet successfully prises himself from the forced image of a writer who writes broken lines to a half-eaten breakfast, then it should be easy to see that the poet absorbs the world. The philosopher is a kind of personal category; a poet too. The philosopher inevitably has agendas, and he can't prise his way out of that. Once that stops, out steps the poet. Are there poets who don't write poetry? Purely absorbing. Eyes to the world; judgement in the bin. Maybe the poet

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becomes a poet once he sees that writing itself is just as arbitrary as, say, writing five hundred pages of rhyming couplets. There's no wall; maybe the poet was never really a writer at all. Names and titles push the formless into wrongful shapes (the poet spends his life writing little verses about the acceptedly sad). There are no limits for something like this and so there's no content too. Everything is used, everything is forgotten the moment it's remembered and the forgetting is no bad thing. Valueless given value.

- 2 Definition one is that the poet realises that everything matters. Meaning form too; it matters how you talk about a thing and not just for getting your point across. Impossible to be right in a clumsy way because the rightness is just one filled hole in the whole. Beauty but broad beauty, abstract and airy, beyond pleasant and familiar. Noumenal beauty. For else there are hierarchies: prejudgements on things thought unnecessary, things called frivolous, waste, pointless. At the poetic edge, everything is seeable as obscurity and now this all-seeing is able to grow in response to it all. Everything let in; we let in language

and then close ourselves off; but it's still the same nonsense hiding behind the sense.

The last letter Hölderlin wrote to his mother – he was 58 years old and it was long after she and the rest of his family had abandoned him in his tower, let alone actually reply to his letters – begins and ends:

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“Forgive me Mother ... Look after me. Time is literal and all-merciful.”

Malaise – which is the poet's disease and his health – malaise is not created by intrusive technology or naughty truth-finding, voyeurs at God's window. No; it's that technology and truth-finding keep the malaise immature. How many does immaturity kill a year? Still, many live on beautifully well (as they should of course). But some are simply made to malaise; they find adventure in malaise. We trust our judgements too much thinking that the bad cannot grow because it's bad and because it's bad it cannot grow. Keeping the ugly in a light tight box; it's too bright.

- 4 The poet accuses others of judging by what's liked, but isn't he meant to be the aesthetic one here? Beatified beauty spotter? But here he is lopped to pieces by overly aesthetic judgements if he believes them too much. Isn't it a bit easy to judge aesthetically? Maybe he should just resist all aestheticising, see how it goes. Definition two. Oh he can be happy. But there is such a thing as malaise. And malaise: that can grow too. The synthesis of the raw world and all its prelanguages, languages which don't look like languages, languages of which language is special language. But like a language spoken these new languages can only be understood by those who speak them. How do we take the cynicism of Hölderlin? Diagnosis of barrenness. His time does not look so barren, looking back; but maybe again that's because I can't see it. To not think the bad can bloom too. I mean the embarrassing, the boring.

There are all kinds of subjective states that seem to exist only as things to be killed and overcome and transformed into newer fitter more desirable states. Ignorance the absence of knowledge; fear the absence of courage; bad the absence of good. And then that only the desirable grows: only knowledge grows, only the good grows. Positivism the view that the opposite is an absence and so empty and so nothing at all. Something that I think mathematicians have learned well that the rest of us are yet to do so in any competent way is that conceptual contradiction is no refutation; that the thing that appears as an empty opposite is in fact a living breathing thing in itself. The history of numbers is one big lesson in this regard: fear of negative numbers (the Greeks, how to count minus nothing); fear of incommensurable numbers (the Greeks, how some shapes dividing shapes are not numbers dividing numbers); fear of imaginary numbers (Descartes, solutions of seemingly purely formal squaring). Reductio ad absurdum the weakest form of argument. And that the mathematicians have learned their lesson well, just see today: the field with

one element doesn't inspire waved away disgust but instead they ask "how does it work?". (In fact today we find all kinds of exotic definitions: consider the generalisation of set cardinality to negative numbers by replacing cardinality with the Euler characteristic.) Mathematicians have learned that the negative is just as much a positive as the plain-looking positive.

- 6 To come to a feeling of something like ignorance—to have been ignorant of ignorance, and now, after long time spent with ignorance, coming to feel ignorance. At the moment where everything gets turned around, the bad is no longer a pathway to death but a condition to a weird kind of life. And not because any bad believing person is right but because he is wrong. Because he is wrong because the wrong isn't so wrong. Man made beautiful by the negative worship of sin, anti-actions in anti-lives. A nose for what smells good, but also not, seeing shit everywhere and stepping around it, dancing across the pavement. Empiricists: do we abstract from the real life smelling flowers and smelling shit raising it to realms outside of its proper

place to a kind of transcendental smelling? Do we smell our ethics (all of our life) because we all know how to smell from real-bodied real life? Where's the kritiker to put down all these new dogmatic dogs?

A more questionly question: how much of the desire to be understood means the making of conditions of understandability? And what's more important: making the thing, or being understood through the thing? In making to not be understood you fashion for yourself a bespoke kind of hell. Which might be fine for ten minutes but ten years? On some level it's indistinguishable from just being bad. What then does it mean to not want to the understood? To seek out everything like you're running. To think that humans are the spies of God and when you see how you look in the mirror it catches you offguard. Such an aberration of clean surfaces and a finding of boring secrets. A love of confusion. Life mask set at a thousand miles and the death mask always close. What does it mean? Malaise is near. No satisfied thing fidgets with itself so much so often. (It has something to protect.) Malaise a timeless

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way of relating. And it's a kind of delusion but a potent delusion. Some malaisiaires: Hölderlin, Grothendieck, Galois, Kerouac, Nietzsche, even little Daniel Johnston. Constant early death or late madness.

- 8 What does it mean when somebody becomes suspicious of good things? The good as that sought; so what then when a person rejects it? Does he just reject that good for his good? Go the other way: what does it mean when a person lives his life by the good? Meaning he seeks out what gives him clear joy, he seeks thoughts which are sensible and are full of meaning. Just as he does no harm to his body he also does no harm to his mind, his whole life: he stays away from things which look painful, he only does what feeds him. Even his transgressions serve what's good: he'll be bad in all the right ways. Here's a disbelief: the analogy between mind and body is only an analogy. Modern monism says that because mind is body, because mind is brain, then everything that is of body is also of mind. So mind-pain is like body-pain: so avoid it, they say.

Poets do everything wrong; they live doing everything wrong; they live wrong. What's to live, for them? For things to be absorbed.

9

VICIOUS VAN GOGH

Of course the good stays good for those rejectors of the good. The rejected good doesn't shrivel into bad after the pain of revelation; and the bad now welcomed in doesn't become a better good once welcomed in. The anointing of the new good and bad doesn't change the look of them. The good exists like anything else on the table. Yes his good is not your good and a one hundred year old good is different to a newborn good weak on its feet. Yes they used to go and laugh at peo-

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ple dangling from beams of wood and now we feel feeble fear watching fake people fakely dangle from fake wood. But there are different goods, things which we smell are good, which project themselves as good.

- 2 An image: someone overcomes something to find a better version of the thing. The big reveal—and conveniently everyone can understand it and see it. The existence of revealers asserted, showing us what we're missing. The revealer contracted out to the watcher: he does the hard work of revealing; and the watcher get a vicarious insight and hopefully a bit of a show too. In return the revealer gets some sort of reward, his name block capitalized in everyone's personal good book. And the dream of the watcher becomes a dream that some begin to take seriously and want. Some make the dream into a kind of reality. Most of human industry isn't about metals or oils but about figuring out how to realise the dream. Establishing conditions of intelligibility, markers of progress, planting checkpoint flags, hidden treasures, untwisting puzzles and clues, building beautiful stages. Scaffolding reso-

lutions, made in institutions, signed with dynasties. Economies of entire countries perch on this nub of dream realisation (economies like England). There are all kinds of techniques that are used to try and squeeze the dream through the silk screen. Quantification is such a despotic mode of valuation that you could say we really are squarely Pythagorean. And equally, naming: a good name as good a despot is as a good number; give something a name, speak well, and suddenly something exists that's undeniable.

Those who step into the soggy sodden shoes of malaise step outside of the dream. The good stays good and the bad bad to the malaisiare too. It may sound dreary but there's no comforting transformation. To step into the bad: to feel bad, to look bad. To be written up into the bad book. Everyone will pretend not to see you. Can you blame those who get stuck and want out? Finding fruits in barren lands still enacts no ethical alchemy; and so status as fruits questioned.

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- 4 What does it mean when we praise a person from the past who would have been sentenced to death by guilt today? What does it mean when they are hyper-valued? Van Gogh loved because his life represents a conversion, the most successful conversion of unvirtuous repulsiveness to a state of fine clear goodness. He didn't double down on the vice, saying it as well as doing it. He won a race with virtue; transformation of hopeless bad into unbelievable good. The absinthe-drinking family-dishonourer, kept alive by a brother's faith unto death. The kind of person nobody liked—and today we judge the judgers. Thinking how closed-minded these people were; their faith in him didn't last. Overstretching every good-will, overstepping every clear line easy to see for everyone else. It's like he was morally blind. His family cast for the future as a bunch of 19th century prudes—that's their legacy. The inverse canonisation where all those around become collateral as we throw them off as bad, and read every act of theirs as dimming the halo.

The life of van Gogh the poster life for the search for virtue, the conversion on the road to Arles. Remember, people used to think of Augustine and Paul the way we think of people like van Gogh. Christianity is just a different set of names; in its organised form it's a developed institutionalisation of social tendencies which are for us today informal and implicit. Modern christians would stone Paul if he happened to flip flop into the room. The life of van Gogh is a life that escapes its unvirtuousness, its viciousness. The dream in full flight. And a dream so patent in himself: clear desires, clear efforts, clear that he too was dreaming the dream, the dream that was then only embryonic.

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It's because virtue is spectacular. Something immediately intelligible like all our arts. Maybe nothing's inherently intelligible but at least spectacle is the show of the intelligible. Virtue, something we can all understand. Virtue, something that beams itself out of itself, bright and clear. Virtue, a firm handshake and a clear enunciation that wins you over. Virtue, any understandable act, an act understood as good. Virtue, a job well

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done. Morality fireworks of every colour. What's harder to understand is a wilful jump into unvirtuousness: the impossibility of saintification. Absolution revoked. The saint has to at least be interpretable as intelligible. A thirst for virtue—not wanting to see things done badly. No thirst for pretty nice things but a thirst for intelligibility, for understanding, for ease. The thirst for virtue thirsts for annihilation too.

- 7 Romanticism is the belief that the perversion of virtue creates new virtues. But the perversion of virtue does not lead to new virtues but leads to a true degradation, as they all warned you it would. Yet it's that these conditions are absorbed like everything else, become meat for intensifications, and even more: they represent the obscurity of values, and thus the condition for intensifications. Virtue itself is an absence of intensification of value. Intensification is an unvirtuous thing: it's an odious sin that never looks good or sounds good. The growth after all may be tumourous. This is why it's funny to see past vicious people like van Gogh (but also like Blake maybe), people who would make a lot of us sick to look at

and think about if they lived today, to see them as held up icons.

In a future of machine intelligence ethics becomes more pressing not because we have to include machines in our thinking (“yes but have we ever considered the problem from the point of view of the trolley?”) but because the following question appears: how does someone stray? What does it mean to stray in a time where everything is already done, where there’ll even be simulations of straying? Acting out played out; virtue ever more enticing. How to go wrong when there’s no longer any excuse to not go right. The strayer loses the last scrap of whatever he had; maybe that’s a good thing. Virtue is sewn into intelligibility, it’s the morality of intelligibility. So what replaces malaise in a time when malaise cannot be? In such a world of achievable virtues, malaise – wilful unachieving – changes too. It’s not to ask the general question ‘how to live?’ because in such a world the virtuous life is infinite and never easier.

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- 9 Something is made when made in vice and that something is something for the future. Because the future looks on this present as a past, and so sees it without its square virtuous eyes. The future, a nice god, gives faith, gives forgiveness. Salvation lies in another time. When the process of history and reflection is disrupted the vicious action is disrupted too. Again: the values of the future are different. Virtue and vice, things of present—wrapped in languages; they are languages. But virtues are tasty cuts of meat tasty in every age. Good things in themselves sit out there, in the sun or in the rain, free to pick up or put down. Still, you hear that the present decorates history with its own particularity, garnishes it with its own garish fashions, plucks the eyeballs of its good dead contemporaries to use as lenses for its senses. That it busies away sorting the past into classes of good and bad as it thinks of good and bad. But from the future the past is seen with different eyes because it's not understood; distance breeds darkness.

Virtue tethered to the present by every rope in the world. What's the present but everything that's intelligible? The future and the past as boundaries of nonsense bounding sense. The present an island of sense. The past and the future have alien values and the line that's threaded through time is a line made out of value. The future is the valueless; so is the past. The future is without virtue; so is the past.

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Virtue is intelligible: the good as the sun. Virtue is the good as intelligible and visible and also the intelligible and the visible as the good. Not only is the bad seen as obscure but the obscure is seen as bad. Van Gogh and his confusing character and no one knowing what to make of him. But he overcame his own particular original sin by making himself intelligible, in performing a final intelligible act. In whipping himself into right. His brother, Theo; staying with him despite the confusion and the darkness. A way of seeing precisely the opposite of what we and everyone else see in someone like that. We don't stay in the face of bad signs. But we rub our hands when we spot someone who gives us no room for doubt.

II

Van Gogh's present disowned him. And now with the insulation of a century, we forget all of his ugliness—the intelligibility that once was evaporates barely leaving a stain—we are safe to praise him however we like. Time made this possible, the moral corrosive. If van Gogh was in France today we'd disown him as much as his own time did, as we do to all those like him but don't seem like him, because of course he didn't seem like him. Virtues do not change—old women leaning over the garden of eden fence; parents crying oceans for their children. Moralities of biologies. Virtue, too bright and too loud to ignore; too much risk, too much cost to going against virtue. All clear cost and unclear everything else.

12 Unvirtue, vice—what does it look like? Is it skepticism about our feelings, our 'hunches'? Not judging too quickly? Looking twice? Carelessness, or looks like carelessness. Saying yes to things which are hard to see and to say no to everything begging for a yes. No sense. Openness to certain things, things which do not beg us to be open to. Ignored, nothing would be lost. Theo stayed with Vincent in

contradiction. He valued his brother in vice. Was it just biology seeping through? Blood overpowering appearances at individual cost; nestbuilding out of instinct, no demonstration needed, can do it blindfolded. But Hölderlin's family abandoned Hölderlin, just as van Gogh's parents abandoned van Gogh. Did Theo place a bet in his hapless, embarrassing brother, that he would come good? Or did he not care about the end at all? Would he have done the same for Vincent if Vincent showed no inclination for anything? What if Vincent did not justify himself through his toil? For even if Theo didn't care if Vincent came good, Vincent definitely cared to come good: to his family; to the world. He had the aspirations of an eight year old. His desire to make things right with those who did not care if he made things right, again like Hölderlin, like when Hölderlin writes to his mother in another unrequited letter

"Forgive me if in its devotion to you my soul should look for words to seek to demonstrate its thoroughness and devotedness. I do not think my conceptions of

you are very far wrong in respect of your virtuousness and kindness. But I should like to know in what ways I must exert myself to be worthy of that kindness, that virtuousness. As Providence has brought me thus far, I hope perhaps to continue my life without dangers and utter doubt. I am your most obedient son, Hölderlin”¹

Again, long after abandonment, long after long time living alone with madness. But now the place in which he lived (in a room in a tower owned by a sympathetic carpenter) is called Hölderlintrum (Hölderlin’s Tower). See? The immediate feelings of the present are dissolved by the future and something else emerges in its place, something the present could not face because it didn’t understand, the power and fear of judgement compelling a small class of rejective actions. The carpenter who housed Hölderlin was from the future: seeing with the eyes of the future – seeing beyond the present – but doing something more because seeing the past from the future is too easy. But of course Hölderlin

¹The letter is actually signed off as ‘Hölderlin’. Funny, why not Friedrich?

justified himself, just as van Gogh justified himself; there would be no Hölderlintrum if he hadn't done what he did, and nobody would care about Vincent van Gogh if he hadn't painted all those wonky chairs and eaten all that paint.

But what is it to act without justification? Perhaps Theo van Gogh acted without justification; perhaps that carpenter acted without justification. But Vincent sought to justify himself—yes, his whole life was a justification for his ugliness—and, as I've said, we love him for this grand act, this seeking clarity and answers, this seeking of sense. But what if Theo was the more interesting van Gogh? Or at least underrated. Vincent taken as a man who took hold of his destiny, who through sheer inner force willed himself to virtue. Transvaluating his whole existence. Yes, van Gogh was hard to love. But was he any different to those who were turned off by him? Would he have done any differently? Was his Jesus-like living with a prostitute the same act of faith as the act of faith of his brother? Or was it just more rudeness?

13

SYMPATHY

If the world is indifferent then why should there be anything that takes tiredness and frustration into account? They used to grip their own hands and beg a god for mercy. But the expectation is still that the world sometimes goes easy. The expectation of a nice layout, not placed there but grown all on its own. Gaia the self-organising god. Wobbly thoughts think indifference as universal heat-death, lightspeed meteor collisions, atmospheres whisked away. But indifference is

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closer; it's right there in judgement, in body and soul.

2 Expectations for reasons and grounds and resolutions and neat things all neatly tied off with bows made out of a mother's words. Or if those words are abandoned – because they're not right not so often enough – then maybe the words of a stranger with a nice name and a nicer life. The first ingredient is that we believe that we can believe, and then that we can disbelieve too. Something doesn't sound like it should, something doesn't seem right, something missing, and this taken as something that can be taken. Because there are all those other things that give sure feelings, things known because they're felt, conspicuous evidences of the value of immediate judgement.

3 To any question of why, of why things should fit together as they do, why things should be done as they're done, a true God gave a true answer. It's a painful question to ask how the godless can be moral, because behaviour is guaranteed by habit and is almost always automatic. But for a God-believing questioner constantly questioning if the

air is good for him, his questionings may eventually stop, satisfied with the idea that whatever is guaranteed by God, known by his belief. If you've got God with you, why not use him?

Without the big guarantor, the water can keep coming in; questions and thoughts as tides, rhythmically destroying any piles of clumped-up sand. God as a ground, a source of reasons to plug up doubt. Of course some God reasons are rightly supplanted by scientific reasons. For God – always inspiring saving – God fits like a glove as an explanation for so much, universal stop.

But as the weak stops of God give way to eternal reasons, the toppling of God's reasons has always made some quite headily ask: might not everything be amenable to big **I** reason? The space of previous paltry God reasons, after supplanting these with real reasons, now this space has bled and spread to cover more things. And why not?

Schopenhauer made a big fat judgement on all of life: that, on the whole, it just wasn't worth it. Sixty years later, Nietzsche judged the act itself of such a judging. Such life judgements are expressions of the biology of the person, so his judge-

ment went. For the hopeless and pain-ridden, life was awful; others more alive saw it as beautiful; both judge accordingly. But what happens when these judgements, and then the judgements on these judgements, all the things that got them up in the morning and put them to bed at night—what happens when the judgements themselves are no longer possible? Beyond right, beyond wrong. Schopenhauer made his judgement; but along with his judgement was a belief in the possibility of his judgement and a belief in a world in receptive harmony: a world of minds open to receiving his judgement. Yes he was ignored for forty years but we can ignore that because he was ignored in favour of Hegel. They all wandered about in a world of sufficient faith, a world with faith enough to take such judgements with earnest naivety.

- 6 Outside of mathematics, the only truth is that judgements are really nothing at all. There's nothing behind or underneath the words. Where there's faith in words, it's just that those words are not yet exposed as words. Receptivity and openness accompany such words taken to be su-

perwords; plain empty words get up and get walking. The mathematician climbs up onto the stage to tell all present the one-to-one correspondence between the subfields of a field and the subgroups of an associated group. The mathematician leaves the stage and is replaced by the philosopher, who then starts telling the audience his view of justice, and also why everyone before him got it wrong. If he's funny, they like him. But of course only mathematics produces proof-findable claims. If there's something outside of mathematics that does then bring it right in; it doesn't matter if it doesn't look like it. But once you've brought in everything that's mathematics-in-hiding, you still have things left over. But what is this value now, these monuments of truth-value sculpture? There's layer upon layer of bewitchment; the creation of sports, games, games in games, institutional rhyme and rhythm setting up expectations and thinking things satisfying those expectations in absolutely aesthetic resolutions. A labyrinth of armoured value ascends from under you: at every turn you have to deny the undeniable. And then what has the homeless ex-

ile got but his words? No-one says a good word about him or his words—no-one even knows his name—how can his words be believed, words which are just words?

- 7 With these unmathematical things all there are are words. Is religion not just this and nothing else? What's the word of God if not words you can trust? And why the need for these supremely trustful words, if not the recognition that all other profane words are trustless nothings? Mathematics contains an invincible iron-chested trust that all your questions will have answers. Whether the answers are positive or negative, or even whether they are impossible to answer, whether I find the answers or not is completely down to my willingness and capacity to find them. Is this a relation between faith and will? The trust here is that undergoing this hard journey into obscurity will, in principle, give some kind of answer, have some kind of resolution. That's to say, the faith – if the absolutely assured can be faithlike – the faith has a ground. There's a reason for my action, and this reason

is perfect: it will never deceive me. If I am deceived, it's only because I deceive myself.

Underneath the writer is a deep dug hole that all his words fall into. There's no proof for words, no right and proper arguments, no appealing to this or that piece of obviousness. There's only whatever the reader chooses to give of him or herself. There's only the sympathy of the reader—and the writer has no control over that. It depends on which side of the bed the reader woke up on; what side of the century they woke up on. Sympathy, shaky nothing thing, conditions reception. It is reception. The maker, the artist, thought of as lord, as visionary genius seer. But so much of this tiring mistakenly placed 'genius' lies in the receptive capacities of the non-artist, the other person who's so often abused by the maker, getting work rudely thrown in their face by an eager people-pleaser, a Vincent-like virtue-seeker. The receptive capacity which knits a synthetic form out of an obscure vicious nothing. Maybe it takes some viciousness to do that. The thing made makes a vicious union. Hope for mind and sympathy and will in the other: a willingness and de-

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sire to engage with whatever it is, despite what it looks like. Despite the hard work that's necessary to uncover it. But it need not exist. It's not something immediate, not innate, not reflex, not easy. It's a capacity, to stay with something that does not yet look like something. And things which do not look like something look weak. Everything falls from the maker's hands as he realises he no longer has any power.

- 9 Equal to what any poet speaks is the possibility of this speaking. Of course not in the funny Kantian determination of this possibility, expecting to find answers through a nice long cosy hibernation and going long on reason. If it is possible – that words can ring in ears – then the work itself would realise this possibility. If the work fails, then either it is not possible or the work's a dud. But in either case the work itself becomes the proof. What do you do when you find out that there isn't anything that can be done to improve the words, to justify them, to make them mind-tight?

We accept objects of sympathy once they're dead. Things christened with the image of being an object of sympathy, as a thing to give sympathy to. And as a result of that they cease to be an object of sympathy. We give ourselves to the difficult works of the past because they are certified as sympathy-rewarding things, as attention-rewarding things. The present thought of as the time where we can see everything, the time of immediate intelligibility. Strapped to this rock of sense that's barely jutting out of the sea, little by little we are able to make other islands of sense. Time transforms an object into an object of sympathy because time makes it unintelligible; and it is the capacity for sympathy which then transforms the unintelligible object into an object of sense. What else is there but this? What does it mean to talk of a capacity for faith? Is it an ability to see an object as worthy of sympathy, and then to be able to persevere with its transformation? The domain is one of ambiguity. There is no verification; no shining "you've made it". The poet's domain is properly in the minds of others and nowhere else. Outside of easy reasons a decision

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on the part of the other person is needed; a person who has chosen to let the work in (or any action). And to do that the person must be similar to the poet. Choice among absence and despair becomes a form of perverse expertise. Choosing without reason and without justification. The poet who is without a proper domain calls this his domain. If the act of the mathematician is naming (naming the nameless, christening, revealing what is there because his domain is things which are there), then the act of the poet is choosing (choosing because, now, nothing is anywhere).

SYMPATHY II

Faith-driven things accepted today because they're things of the past—and the past accepted as faith-driven. To accept human actions without reason requires faith and sympathy; there's no reason to even go near them. On the contrary, there's all the reason to stay away. Things of past lauded but this afterglow greatness is no reason for their existence in the moment; in the moment they're nothing; and so if nothing's

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nothing, just roughness and boredom, then nothing can live.

- 2 Don't take me the wrong way but those things are great in exactly the same way that God is great. And now the difficulty is made precise. To accept the possibility of greatness in a work is to accept or at least understand the possibility of God being great. No need to be religious or even believe in God (because who can?). But these things have no extra justification: not aesthetics, not practical life advice, not some histrionic emotionalism. Nothing justifies them. And God's the same: the ultimate case of unjustification.

- 3 I mean that this is how it is with the less godly too. These things which are at first glance still tied firmly to the ground. These things we like and come closer to because they have a softer, more intelligible, more sensible face. But behind you'll find the same big bloodied abscess abyss as what you find in looking for God. God and mathematics are the only things which don't show themselves as something they're not.

Of course God doesn't exist. But a person who can't get God can't get God because he's always looking for evidence of God: it's looking for evidence which prevents the idea of God—once he stops looking for evidence, he finds God. Twisted logomachism: the act of looking for evidence prohibits the idea of God, the feeling of God, the language of God. God doesn't exist and that's the point. A man complains there's no evidence for God and says that's why he can't believe in the idea of God, why he can't feel God. But there's another man who does feel God but who does not feel God because he has evidence of God: he also has no evidence for God. But he sees that there is no evidence for God except the idea of God itself. God's a matter of perspective. Russell and co would have said there's no evidence for many things, things we don't have any awareness of, yet we don't believe in them, and would even cite their lack of evidence as the reason why.

Can the God-believer say he believes in the idea of God but not that God exists? Perhaps the teapot that's circling the Sun somewhere between Earth and Mars, perhaps if someone decided to

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somehow 'believe' in the teapot, and so believe without justification, then maybe it would become the same thing as those who believe in God without evidence. Not a question of God nor teapots. A question of belief without justification. Any and all kinds of objects may get you there but once in maybe it's just one thing. God becomes a word to get a foot in the door of the sans justification. Perhaps it's even that the idea of God is uniquely special enough that it allows this to happen. That something like the teapot doesn't; it always brings mind back down to ground; a line of reasons traceable, either to prove or refute. But God so impossible, so wrong, so inexistent, and yet that might make the God-word that one singular thing that so decadently defies being strung up on a line of reasons.

- 6 Now extend this outside the garden of God to our mundanity. Does a painter look for evidence of the existence of him being a painter when, after thinking why oh why does he do it, he thinks "well, I feel good when I paint, I like what I see, others seem to like what I do—yes, then I must be a painter I suppose". And can there be another

painter, painter B, who paints yet who doesn't look for evidence of his being a painter and rather paints even though he has no right to? What does it mean to do something without any right to? The painter who paints without justification is the person who paints even though he's not a painter in any normal sense; everything else tells him that, maybe, he's living a fantasy and a charade. Yet he paints not only without the cushion of explicit evidences of payment and good words but also without subtler evidences found around him, little things telling him "yes, you are justified in doing what you do".

Human actions and all kinds of made objects are amenable to reason. There may be a hidden absence behind them, but out in front there's a great big trap for reasons, and they can get fat on them. Maybe God would just simply die if fed reasons, die because there's no hollow form to take its place. I've such trouble with the God word, just saying it feels stupid. But everything else, that called 'culture', really is no different to the God word. Yes, you can see culture as this land of seeable seas and an infinite chess-

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board where you get to choose your piece and touch swords. But this vulnerability to intelligibility, to easy reasons, is not the tuber of culture but the tumour. Reason is golden. This permission to find real stuff that lasts forever; packed up in soil from Earth and shipped up to heaven. Real, awe-ful power. Reasons are mouldy. They have their place but they are tumourous; they overstep. God doesn't exist but the God word lives because it is immune to easy reasons, just like mathematics lives because it's immune to easy reasons. There's no half-understanding in mathematics. And there's no understanding of God, not even a half-understanding. Two poles of decadent transcendence. All other things are brought down to the ground. Maybe the spacial teapot could become the occasion for an act without justification, but its concreteness kills.

ENGLAND

To say anything about your home has failure baked into the urge. You're an idiot for even considering it. Never mind if what you're gonna say isn't a eulogy. You've only got one home—tops two or three—how do you know what you think you see in your home isn't just some more general world-thing? And how do you know what you see around you isn't actually just you (your eyes)? After all, you too are a sprout of your home—you'd be as much a perpetrator as your home would be

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a victim. And then why would your home be a home and not homes? How local do homes get? Is the global home obtainable by gluing local homes in an infinite chain of home extensions?

- 2 England does its best to kill its poets. It really, really tries. Any shame a malaised man feels isn't necessarily his fault, though the malaise is mostly him. Maybe it's obvious but I consider myself a man in malaise. (Who else would write this?) Looking back I got it very young, maybe too young, though at the time I thought I was ancient. And I'd like to say I don't suffer from shame, brave soul I am. And sometimes that's true. It's been true recently. The proof that it's been true is right in front of you. Perhaps I can only be vague and say it comes and goes in waves. I certainly suffered from it in the beginning. For a few years it was incessant: wants turned different but ability to articulate or even know what was happening was lacking; thoughts turning on self, thinking the self is bad, bad for being bad, for not being up to good. I waddled about with this sack of shame for something like four years,

maybe more. And then, at least for a bit, it disappeared. Why'd it go? Where'd it go?

For a while I thought it was a kind of inner acknowledgment of certain outer achievements. In the beginning nothing worked; I'd try so much yet every time I'd fall over (note how trying is perhaps the most pungent symptom malaise). But eventually things do begin to work, if in small ways. I thought it was this that brought me out of my shame, a kind of recognition that things were actually ok, my body responding in turn. But I doubt this today. And not just because I've since realised that the shame never actually goes away. But that, in relation to 'achievement' – which is the achievement of virtue, of resolution, of gaining intelligibility – it wasn't that I found reassurance, beginning to feel that everything was ok, my tiny heart-hands clasped knowing it'd all come good in the end god bless. Rather it was the same as any other confrontation with obscurity: out of persistence, a peace is made. Or, really, a truce. For malaise is an obscurity; it's in an obscurity of the value of want and action. You want differently, but you don't know what;

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you do differently, but you don't know why. And a peace is made because an intuition is gained, if unconsciously. And maybe this is accompanied by an outer ability, some capacity, some won virtue. But that's just a surface. I didn't come to terms with being bad by becoming good—no, in many respects I stayed bad. Yes, I could do some new things. But the peace, the disappearance of shame—that wasn't from 'coming good'. It was from losing the baby-tooth desire to come good.

4 Malaise is turning bad. Shame is the longing to come good once turned bad. Do I have to say what turning bad is? It's not turning 'evil'. It's possibly but not necessarily: turning clumsy; loss of concern for appearance; not seeking big prizes; not seeking to amaze; being a bit rough in manner (charmless); being too shy; not being shy enough; gaining a cynical eye; turning off of others and turning off others; turning much too inward. It's falling short of virtue and not having the desire to make it back up. Though it's true the real 'evil' ones might not be bad enough. The shame that can come with malaise is properly an attitude of horror to all this that's happening, your-

self watching yourself turn into a monster. But, of course, the shame is the real motor of the monster—the shame goes and so does the monster, and not just to yourself.

It's not insignificant that I first encountered malaise when I was far away from home for the first time. And I mean far away from England. Again maybe homes are homes and familiarity is familiarity. But what I witnessed in my time away – a time that I was lucky enough enough to have experienced (because it didn't have to happen) – what I witnessed in myself, this kind of eruption of new desires and new prohibitions, this made me look back, look back over the narrow dividing sea, and see England for what it had always been to me: a smog of noise; a kind of pressure factory producing pressure cooker minds; a place where even the soil had a right and a wrong. It's not a place of priests – quite the opposite – but still the economy trades in straitjackets and latches. A kind of numbness by excess exists in England: there's too much to do, too much apparent possibility, too many lights, too many ad-men dressed smart-casual. There are too many futures, ready-

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made and steaming. Too many paths; too many keys; too many traps.

- 6 Speaking generally, England – I so willingly declare – is guilty of two things: obstructing malaise; and inducing shame in the malaised. The two are linked. I don't know why or how England got this way—maybe it's life in its megapolis. Still, England does its best to kill its poets. But how could it not? I'm not asking for it to change (perhaps I like it the way it is). But none of this changes the fact that England kills its poets. Perhaps in England I find a symbol, a mask, a scheme, a plot. The chasing after intelligibility at all costs, backed by the things won—goodness, good words, good deeds. Frequent experience with the light and with clarity making you sure that not only is the path you stand on the right path but that there are paths to be stood on at all. A place where not even falling short happens without virtue. This is one of the faces of shame. The falling man stumbles—yet he never lets go of what he thinks is good and right, even if he continuously does what's bad, does vice. Shame and guilt. He falls into moral debt. “I'll come good

eventually, just give me some time.” The man who lives in shame longs for the good: he thinks uprightly, but does badly. This is van Gogh’s shame. It’s Hölderlin’s shame. And, yes, it’s my shame too.

In England you can live a good life. The good life? Good life here means: there are plenty of distractions and diversions and divertissements; there are plenty of structures in place which give you a clean idea of the future, straight paths partitioned into sections with chalk, tackleable in small skips and hops. Of course the tragedies of life – injury and death – haunt the English as they haunt everyone else. Life might not play out as expected; the straight path is indeed found to be crooked; the job no golden chest at the end of a journey but a hole you can’t escape from. You’ll feel all the sharp brittle shards of life that economy is unable to keep out. And, of course, you might find yourself outside of the economy, as many do, unable to find your way back in, all through no choice of your own. And no one will look after you then. Some are born outside the economy. Yes economy is so easily and so of-

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ten brutal—Russian roulette games where we're all given a gun. But brutal or not economy is a place of big life games, and England is a place of big economy. A place where you pick out and barter for the structures of your own life. This is the prize of economy, the prize of civilisation. Someone said to me once that we've 'solved boredom'. So is economy some kind of discovery machine? A discovery itself?

- 8 Perhaps the most depressing fact of English life is the relentless ease with which England completely extinguishes its youth. Pencil-pusher of the soul, English economy fills the young with imperatives and said-to-be-important tasks, tasks that must be fulfilled before anything else can be done. By the time a person's twenty or so, they'll have a long list of economic things-to-do, things-to-want. Brought to the gates, those called best are chomping at the bit. England forces its youth to think of economic futures. The young thinks he can't afford to be frivolous: he's got a life to build—there's no time to waste. The fact that building is possible, the fact that he can and does build a life of sorts—they weren't lying. There

are a million buildings for a young person to enter, superfamilies he gets to choose to be part of. There are so many possibilities—how could any young person even think about taking his eye off them? How could he not carefully pick any of them out?

Regimentation is not found in the sodium-glown paper stacks of the apparatchik but rather in the dreams of children. It's the "I want to be..."—which naturally transforms into "I want to have..."—before sputtering out into silence as the person exits youth and realises he has no future left in which to put his economic wants. But this freedom from the economy-future is still a freedom, despite the viciousness that's there bubbling around it. A time when you no longer want, when you no longer believe that you can have.

The person who enjoys a freedom like this—he must enjoy his vice and endure his shame. Do I wish it on anybody else? An English anybody else? It's too much—because the asked person is essentially asked to give up. He or she would sacrifice them and their economic future to an ugly god. Act number one would have to be to stop

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chasing economy's tail, in action and thought. Shame is the lust for the must of the economy-future without the will to attain it. And the thing with undeniableness is that they're undeniable: desires that don't die. The big truth, though, is that heaven's already and always been right there below your nose, it just smells bad.

LEARNING TO DIE

The title of one of Montaigne's essays translates
as

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THAT TO STUDY PHILOSOPHY IS TO LEARN TO
DIE

Life and death creep back into the picture. Words frantically scratching at the floor, trying to grab at any small significance, anything. However in this case the hyperbolic surface is actually warranted. Only change philosophy to po-

etry, and, well, since you don't study poetry, not like that, change the wording slightly, perhaps to something like

TO LIVE POETICALLY IS TO LEARN TO DIE

Still it doesn't do much to lessen the attempted word-slap, nor does it lessen the tiredness at seeing poor weak words even attempt a slap. I mean, I can watch people die in the palm of my hand if I wanted—you can too—what are big bad words gonna do to me? They're pretty much a fraud shown to be a fraud. We've learned how to build electric chairs custom-fitted to our nerves; words are old things now.

- 2 Yet to be alone for a long time is like trying to peek a look at death. And sometimes you take a bigger peek than at others. Is it like grieving? Once you remove future fury of busy events, forty years can shrink to forty days. Time melts away under the heat of your new heart, and death feels like it lives in tomorrow. Because it's never death that you feel: it's the day of your death, the time of your death, how you think about the span-of-life in between you and your death. You might

not know exactly, but you know it roughly, and that's enough: death-smelling's an indeterministic science.

This kind of life lacks life. Or it's truer to say it has less of a certain type of life, a certain type of life packaged as life. Here it's life not so readily thought of as life. It's life which makes room for death. You may get more events, more life-matter, more filler to fill the life-bag, but the secret tragedy is that you can only do that with certain things. The line between value and feeling is cut. If you see the filler as the good—well then good. But not everything can go into the bag. There are things over in the corner, things which have a warning sign, telling you not to put them in your bag, your life-bag-for-life bag. Things too big, too sharp, too corrosive. After all, the bag's actually a thin delicate thing; it can't hold as much as you think; really you might just be protecting the bag.

A poet like this does not come to terms with death but gets acquainted with the feeling that he will die; a soft-delusion of sorts sets into him and he begins to experience life as if he didn't

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have much of it left. It's the mode of life, and not thought, which learns us death; which is why it's not a study of philosophy and rational trickery which will get you death but a life of poetry. The poet lives as if he will die. This is the reward for all his negating, all his paring away, all his time alone. He doesn't induce a magic spark; he doesn't find the silver pen with which to write the big best book. He finds nothing. He finds nothing but a feeling of the inevitable end.

- 5 The question in Montaigne's pen: how can I mitigate the terror of death before it comes to face it well when it comes? How to make a bad situation better. Do poets seek the poet-silence which pulls death nearer, to die better? Better and braver for you and for those around you. This is the value Montaigne saw in active thinking on death in life. Prudence. Because, when it comes to you and to those around you, it's already too soon; and so there's no better time to start. That's what philosophy wins you: strength through simulation and illumination, illumination of petty, irrational fears. The overcoming of the fear of death as a virtue and a craft: rich ataraxia. They

could probably hold competitions to see who's the best atarachic. Does the poetic quickening of the end bring the same serenity? What if, when death came, the fear shed you like old skin, and now, as the shape of fear itself, you trembled as hard as he whose life was dense with events?

The poet's life of death does not prepare him for living a better death. Transcendence crawls in as the poetic individual begins to argue that you cannot judge by material outcomes, by Earthly evidences, by things as they appear. What then would this transcendent value of nothingness be? You do something and it makes no difference to your life. It's as if you never did it at all. Does the poet learn to die? What if he really learns nothing? Why should he win some kind of invisible mind virtue, courage, patience, calm? For the mischievous nonsensical wasteful poet, who acts without prudence and misplaces all his virtues, his death-living, though it does make him feel that he will die soon, cannot be said to teach him a lesson. What if he fears the death that's near—does that refute him, and would he do well to run away from it?

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7 The poet sees his salvation in the future. He doesn't think of afterworlds or underworlds or overworlds. Yet the values of the future are different. He pins his hopes on a future which has long since lost the sense for his straying, for his rejection, not because they don't know it – they have plenty of it in living on as their present – but because they are numb to the straying of past times. The poet lives for the long unmaking because he sees himself unmade in this unmaking—yet he makes made things, things that lie there waiting to be picked up. But isn't this just the same as that funny Kantianism, the desire to write the prologue to the future? Perhaps there exists a dance with time, one that Kant danced clumsily and too eagerly. In the future your words will not make any sense; you certainly can't do the future a favour by writing its introduction. The future gods – quite literally our children – will just laugh you away; they'll laugh at your presumptuousness until they no longer bother to even look at you at all. We are fodder for them; powerless to interject, to correct, to manipulate. Food for their thought. A sense for history is more than

just figuring out what happened. Kant holding on heavy-handedly to his cluttered raft of values, 18th century curiosities of thought and will and belief. If he wanted immortality he should have done mathematics. Euclid wrote a zukünftig prolegomenon; as did Fermat; as did Euler; as did Gauss; as did Galois; as did Riemann. So what has the poet figured out that Kant did not? Has he figured anything out? Of course the poet – the time-transcendentalist – does not presume to speak of the future, let alone predict it. He is oh so respectful; he knows he is an ant to his gods, and he knows he will become an ant to the ants of the gods of his gods, and so on until he dissipates out of existence without sound sight or smell. He knows the only thing he can say about the future is nothing at all; yet the future exists, assuming a sense for history exists. And so it becomes an apophatic matter: how to speak about that which cannot be spoken about? Perhaps the poet knows the only thing he can write is a dedication.

- 8 While the religious disappear into deluded non-action, virtue-hunters raze the diversity of present productions by raising walls. Every virtuous act holds the tail of the one in front in its mouth, indistinguishable pink livestock trotting eyes-down to their end. Heads are now firmly in the world; ears and eyes are hypertuned to variations in value. Lists are made and half the world is found wanting. But this anxiety circus of yelling and admonishing (which people do to themselves too) how is this seen with the faraway eyes of the future? The content falls away; the undeni-ables dissolve and become air; once that's done all that's left is a miniscule residue of similarly shaped, similarly coloured things, things which look like that may have once meant a lot to a lot of people but which now mean nothing. The future desiccates the present, finding most of it was water-weight.
- 9 A poet's work becomes a prayer to the future if only because his present cannot see him, nor would he want it to. He probably can't even see him. Because his kind of poetry is not a present thing. It is whatever steps outside of easy intel-

ligibility; it's whatever requires vicious sympathy to see. And those of the present who see it see it with eyes of the future. The poet has no fear of the loss of livelihood and recognition that machine intelligence will bring. He already has no livelihood and he expects no recognition. But he believes in the different sight that the future has and that the present does not. Unburdened with virtue and vice and all the undeniable confrontations with present value, the future looks on the past differently. But always only if the future has a sense for history. The poet depends on history. And by history I don't mean a furtive sifting through old papers but a desire to live with a foreign past. The desire to see the natural horizon of intelligibility and a willingness to occasionally cross it. Because history, like the future, can die. We don't need it. And when this desire for history dies – which is when the past is kept alive as a present of zombie images – then the poet will be judged for eternity. Or machine intelligence will hide the past and create an image of the past which is really a form of the present: an intelligible past that we can judge;

a past we can think with all the safe and easy undeniableness and immediately-intelligibles which constitute the present. The exit finally painted over.

IO It's in this moment – this moment of perfect past-present manufacture – that for the first time something like hell will truly exist, at least for those malaised and shamed. A state where the potency of past badness and vice stays just as live and potent as present vice; a state where our eulogies to virtue and things-to-eulogise-about will simply never stop; a dream world where a thousand years is as intelligible as every coming moment. A world where the present reclaims not just the surrounding sea but every ocean, enacting a state of undying moral judgement. An absolute moral universe.

II So now we have our answer. The poet learns to die in the present, and, maybe, he might learn to live in the future. Not in any sense of remembrance; he probably won't even use his real name. But whatever he makes he makes for the future, and hopes the future will still exist as something else.

